



Decoding Decathlon's Branding Strategy

Case Study

This case was written by **Sharmila Majumdar** and reviewed by **Dr. A. Saravanan Naidu**, Amity Research Centers Headquarter, Bangalore. It is intended to be used as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a management situation. The case was compiled from published sources.

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*"Now more than ever, the world needs sport. It has a unifying power, and can improve both physical and mental health. At Decathlon, we want to have a greater positive impact on humans, society and the planet by Moving People Through the Wonders of Sport. I am proud to be working towards the North Star - our guiding light and ambition - with our teammates. It's been incredible to see our diverse community come together to celebrate what makes us special: enabling everyone to practise sport on their own terms. I am confident that our ambitious strategy, evolving our way of doing business, will ensure Decathlon leads the sector as a unique and trusted sports brand."*¹

– Barbara Martin Coppola, Global CEO, Decathlon

*"Decathlon has been present internationally for 48 years, and its identity dates back to the '90s... It was simply time for a bit of change and modernity, but with respect to our heritage."*²

– Philippe Gariépy, Brand Marketing Manager, Decathlon Canada

Global sporting goods industry was going through a critical time. On the one hand, it was dealing the challenges like supply chain disruptions, geo-political uncertainties, soaring inflation. On the other, as people were picking up sports that required less commitment, and skill and more like a social activity, consumer demand for sports gear was increasing. However, the experiences across the countries varied significantly. Amidst such uncertainties, the companies that were able to discern the challenges and the opportunities in advance, and accordingly aligning themselves through cost-effective measures, retail innovations and/or by adopting trend-responsive branding, were able to grow their market shares.³

Exploring the growth opportunities Decathlon, the world's third largest sports retailer, decided that the time was right to grab the attention of a bigger audience by reinstating its purpose of business. It had already taken up multiple strategies to pursue its ambitious growth plan. To draw attention towards that, in the year 2024, it launched a new logo, 'The Orbit'.⁴ For the last

¹ "Decathlon refreshes brand identity with a new 'orbit' logo", <https://www.afaqs.com/news/mktg/decathlon-refreshes-brand-identity-with-a-new-orbit-logo>, March 13th 2024

² Benembarek Sheima, "Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play", <https://strategyonline.ca/2024/03/26/decathlon-is-ready-to-rebrand-and-play/>, March 26th 2024

³ Becker Sabine, et al., "Time to move: Sporting goods 2024", <https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/retail/our-insights/sporting-goods-industry-trends>, January 30th 2024

⁴ Faithfull Mark, "Decathlon Results Back New Strategy To Take On Sports Super Brands", <https://www.forbes.com/sites/markfaithfull/2024/04/04/decathlon-results-back-new-strategy-to-take-on-sports-super-brands/?sh=2eb8d11f2528>, April 4th 2024

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48 years of its business journey, the brand had transcended across many territories without an official visual icon.⁵ But why at this stage, it felt the need to emphasise on a perfect visual representation for its business ambition? Would Decathlon's new visual identity be able to capture its brand message accurately and adequately?

Evolutionary Brand Strategy of Decathlon: A Glance

In the year 1975, Michel Leclercq (Leclercq) parted his ways from his family business to pursue his dream. His dream was to sell affordable sports gear. In the following year, he hired another six young sports enthusiasts, who had little experience in retail business. But their passion for sports and determination to do something to promote it, held them together. The culmination of their joint efforts gave birth to Decathlon, whose purpose was to bring: "All sports, under the same roof, accessible and available, with a good mood as a bonus..."⁶ Decathlon, the name itself encapsulated top ten sports that the business was initially planning to focus on and feature in its stores. Nonetheless, its largely wanted to bring "All sports under one roof."⁷

Decathlon opened its first store in Northern France in 1976. Within a decade of its inception, it started expanding its business beyond France.⁸ During the first 25 years of its business journey, it continued to expand its business in the European market, mainly in Germany, Spain, Italy, and Portugal. In the following decades, it decided to venture further, into the Asia and the US. In the year 2003 and 2009 it opened its first store in China and India respectively. In 2019, it set the foot in Japan, and the US. The company followed careful global expansion strategy. It pursued localised approach, but also remained loyal to its core business ethos and followed the uniform product and marketing strategy.⁹ It claimed: "we highlight the quality of the cheapest product and the low price of the top-of-the-range product!"¹⁰

Decathlon's Product Strategy

During the initial years of its business, as a newcomer Decathlon struggled to convince other product manufacturers. Sharing personal experience, Benoît Poizat, one of the founding members of Decathlon, said, "At the beginning, manufacturers did not want to sell us their products. We covered every base and eventually, one by one, accepted." They faced the refusal because major manufacturers were unwilling to accept the reduced margins. To overcome the challenges Decathlon decided to collaborate with a local bicycle manufacturer in Lille, a northern city in France. Back in 1986, as a first 'in-house' product, it launched its bicycle, under the 'Decathlon' brand.¹¹

⁵ Schwarz Hunter, "One of the world's biggest sports brands didn't have a logo . . . until now", <https://www.fastcompany.com/91064506/one-of-the-worlds-biggest-sports-brands-didnt-have-a-logo-until-now>, March 21st 2024

⁶ "The founders of Decathlon: the gang of 7", <https://engagements.decathlon.fr/les-fondateurs-decathlon-la-bande-des-7>

⁷ "Our sports 'startup' turns 45 years old", <https://www.decathlon.com/blogs/inside-decathlon/our-sports-startup-turns-45-years-old>

⁸ "Decathlon's story – our key dates", <https://sustainability.decathlon.com/decathlons-story-our-key-dates>

⁹ "Inside Decathlon: The Success Story of A Brand Making Sports Accessible", <https://vue.ai/blog/leaders-in-retail/decathlon-innovatio/>, June 30th 2019

¹⁰ "The founders of Decathlon: the gang of 7", op.cit.

¹¹ "Our sports 'startup' turns 45 years old", op.cit.

Since then, for a while, Decathlon decided to follow single-brand policy. It had its own products, with which it established its dominance in the French market. However, while catering to larger audience, it suffered due to limited product diversity. It always wanted to serve wide variety of sports demand. At the same time, it was committed to maintain product quality and affordable price points. That led to the introduction of passion brands. For that, it went on adding '84 sports-oriented brands', serving different customer segments of various sports, sportsperson with various calibre, from beginners to professionals. To satisfy these diverse customers, Decathlon invested in research and product developments and maintained very high quality of its products.

Decathlon continued to fine-tune its product strategy to establish itself as a complete sport retailer. In that mission it decided to prioritise its own products over international brands. While it kept on increasing its product variety, introduced many ultra-specialised products, it systematically reduced the reliance and visibility of other global brands from its stores.¹² While following that, to adequately satisfy the customer demand with its own products, Decathlon employed qualified designers and product engineers and collaborated with expert manufacturing units to support its business catering to over 80 different sports.¹³ This strategy helped the brand to have greater control over pricing and safeguard its margins, even when it was selling affordable goods.¹⁴

Eventually in the year 2023 when the company was drafting its ambitious 'transition plan' for a 'more profitable, more digital, more environmental' business journey, it felt the need to completely revise its business vision, brand identity, as well as business goal.^{15,16} In line with that, in the year 2024, Decathlon declared its next phase of business journey, as it was planning to simplify its brand portfolio. It decided to have only nine specialist verticals namely: 'Quechua for mountain; Tribord for water and wind; Rockrider for outdoor cycling; Domyos for fitness; Kuikma for racket; Kipsta for team sports; Caperlan for wildlife; Btwin for urban gliding and mobility; and Inesis for target'.¹⁷ The brand eyed for revised brand positioning by streamlining its product portfolio. It planned to eliminate 30 of its 49 existing brands. For example, brands like Artengo, catering to racket sport, or Elops, brands for cycling were to be removed and absorbed by brands like Quechua, an outdoor sport brand, or Domyos, fitness brand, or Decathlon, an umbrella brand for multisport. Such simplification of brand portfolio was expected to smooth out the digital experience of customers. At the same time, it would also lower stock-related costs.¹⁸ (Exhibit I).

¹² S. Kumar Aditya, "Decathlon's Evolutionary Brand Strategy in the Sport Retail Industry", <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/decathlons-evolutionary-brand-strategy-sport-retail-industry-sahoo/>, August 17th 2023

¹³ "Our sports 'startup' turns 45 years old", op.cit.

¹⁴ "Decathlon's Evolutionary Brand Strategy in the Sport Retail Industry", op.cit.

¹⁵ Vanderschelden Diane, "Decathlon, the financial implications of its Transition Plan", <https://fashionunited.uk/news/business/decathlon-the-financial-implications-of-its-transition-plan/2023081771111>, August 17th 2023

¹⁶ Lijbaart Sylvana, "Decathlon's transition to a 'multi-specialist company': From logo to store concept", <https://fashionunited.in/news/business/decathlon-s-transition-to-a-multi-specialist-company-from-logo-to-store-concept-1710501495/2024031544149>, March 15th 2024

¹⁷ Hill Eloise, "Decathlon unveils global rebrand as it overhauls logo, stores, and business model", <https://www.retailgazette.co.uk/blog/2024/03/decathlon-global-rebrand/>, March 12th 2024

¹⁸ "Decathlon, the financial implications of its Transition Plan", op.cit.

Exhibit I Decathlon's Brand Portfolio



Source: Sanghavi Jinal, "The Economics of Decathlon",
<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/economics-decathlon-jinal-sanghavi/>, March 23rd 2022

Decathlon's Digital Strategy

Decathlon's growth plan bestowed great deal of emphasis on digital technology. For example, to reach out to its potential customers, Decathlon relied on digital innovation for complete overhauling of its e-commerce platform. Its aim remained to attract its audience through seamless online shopping experiences. For that, its official website had undergone a massive revamp. For immersive retail experiences, Decathlon's technology experts had developed 3D shopping App. It was leveraging advanced digital tools, and AI algorithms, to discern customer trends and accordingly align its business through optimisation of inventories, improving delivery competence, etc.^{19,20}

Decathlon's Store Strategy

To exceed the image of blue shoebox, and enhance its physical stores, Decathlon decided to leverage digital technology. It decided to introduce a completely new store concept adopting 'digital first' approach. Apart from direct selling, these stores served other purposes to offer an immersive shopping experience. The stores handled orders and returns. It had workstation to offer repairing services. The store staff were well equipped to handle queries and giving product information. To facilitate easy navigation, in-store displays maintained separate segments for different sports. In some places similar categories were clubbed together to help the buyers in discovering the right products. The displays were arranged to lure the customers to try new sport. Even the design of the fitting areas offered personalised experience. Finally, for frictionless shopping experience, the shops installed multiple QR scan stations across the stores. Its products had individual scannable QR codes. The buyers could use these to know the prices, availability, to have additional information about the products, to know the updated price or discounts, etc.²¹ Before the opening of its new-age store in Vancouver, Decathlon Canada's Brand Marketing Manager, Philippe Gariépy (Gariépy) informed, "We'd like to challenge the typical Decathlon concept: big box, mass merchandising and long aisles. We're

¹⁹ "Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play", op.cit.

²⁰ "Decathlon unveils global rebrand as it overhauls logo, stores, and business model", op.cit.

²¹ "Decathlon's transition to a 'multi-specialist company': From logo to store concept", op.cit.

currently testing several avenues, some of which have a more boutique look that does justice to the quality of our products. We want to offer a shopping experience that's tailored to the sporting needs of our communities. In the future, we may open stores with a more specific offer around a group of sports and activities.”²² (Exhibit II).

Exhibit II
Decathlon Store in Vancouver: A Sneak Peek



Source: Chan Kenneth, “Decathlon to open 38,000 sq ft flagship sporting goods store at Metrotown mall”, <https://dailyhive.com/vancouver/decathlon-vancouver-store-burnaby-metropolis-at-metrotown>, October 13th 2023

Decathlon as Service Provider

As a part of its transition plan, Decathlon was making conscious attempt to surpass the image of a distributor or just a sporting goods store.²³ For that, it carefully scripted its market capture plan and simultaneously met its sustainability commitments. The retailer decided to offer innovative services from its stores. For example, Decathlon introduced rental services in response to the changing consumer demand for various sports equipment. Such services offered the customers greater flexibility and convenience.²⁴ From Decathlon's stores, customers could hire bikes, kayaks, or even different sporting equipment, like tennis rackets, etc. In the year 2023, the retailer pledged to make provision of £1 million to support this scheme. The company announced that, with this initiative it: “aims to make the joy of sports more accessible to people by allowing them to pick up something new at a fraction of the retail price.”

Chris Allen (Allen), Sustainability & Circular Economy leader at Decathlon UK, elaborated the idea behind this scheme and boasted, “Despite having the appetite to try sports, committing to the cost of buying gear is one of the biggest barriers to people taking up something new. Rentals gives customers across the UK the opportunity to overcome this challenge by

²² Toneguzzi Mario, “French Sports Retailer Decathlon Repositioning with Renovated Stores and Brand Signage, Including Canadian Locations”, <https://retail-insider.com/retail-insider/2024/03/french-sports-retailer-decathlon-repositioning-with-renovated-stores-and-brand-signage-including-canadian-locations/>, March 12th 2024

²³ “Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play”, op.cit.

²⁴ “Decathlon's Evolutionary Brand Strategy in the Sport Retail Industry”, op.cit.

discovering the joy of different activities at an affordable price and in a sustainable way. We are proud to be the first business to offer nationwide rentals and this is a positive step forward for sustainable sports retail.”²⁵

Decathlon Supporting Sustainability

To take its sustainability efforts even further in the UK, Decathlon introduced buyback services. The customers got in-store credit while returning products that they no longer use or need. These products were refurbished and made ready for reselling. These efforts were part of Decathlon's 'second-life scheme'. In late 2023, in Europe, Decathlon was reported to have bought and sold nearly 251,000 of such items. Disclosing future plan, the retailer further announced that it would expand this service in UK, where it would refurbish 15,000 bikes each year by the year 2025. Decathlon trained 1,500 staff to execute its plan for circular services, that included, rentals and buyback. Allen emphasised that Decathlon saw its business gains from such schemes. It would drive its business even when the business environment was hostile, and also help the communities. He explained, “With the cost of living still continuing to impact sport and fitness participation across the UK, at Decathlon we are determined to ensure that sport participation continues and is not affected by the rising cost of goods. Buyback will allow customers to return their old and unwanted sporting equipment for store credit to use on refreshing their kit.”²⁶

By promoting circularity, such initiatives would help the company to fulfil its commitment to reach Net Zero emissions goal by the year 2050. For reaching that target, Decathlon had set short term milestones that the business pledge to meet by 2026 and 2030. For example, the brand had promised to decarbonise its supply chain and enhance product lifecycles. In line with that, its rental and product buy-back schemes were designed to encourage communities to embrace the culture of 'reuse, repair and recycle'.²⁷

With these series of initiatives Decathlon had been preparing itself “to become one of the most inclusive organisations in the world” while fulfilling “unprecedented commitments for 2026, including measuring representation, inclusion and belonging, acting on it, and setting global standards and best in class performance in DEI (diversity, equity and inclusion).”²⁸ At a time when the company was aspiring to leave a significant impression as a 'global sports brand', it thoughtfully weaved such strategies to infuse elements of vitality in its business.²⁹ Barbara Martin Coppola, CEO of Decathlon, further articulated the future vision of the company and its plan to take up bigger role as a responsible business: “This includes recreating our customer experience, accelerating the movement towards sustainability, and modernising our company end-to-end.”³⁰

²⁵ Morgan Aoife, “Decathlon rolls out rental service to all its stores”, <https://www.retailgazette.co.uk/blog/2023/03/decathlon-rental/>, March 29th 2023

²⁶ Morgan Aoife, “Decathlon launches buyback service across stores nationwide”, <https://www.retailgazette.co.uk/blog/2023/10/decathlon-buyback-service/>, October 24th 2023

²⁷ “Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play”, op.cit.

²⁸ Bhoora Ritika, “Decathlon presents new brand identity as it revises global ambitions”, <https://www.retail-week.com/sports-and-leisure/decathlon-presents-new-brand-identity-as-it-revises-global-ambitions/7045786.article>, March 12th 2024

²⁹ Williams Megan, “Decathlon marks a fresh chapter with new branding and campaign”, <https://www.creativereview.co.uk/decathlon-sports-branding-campaign-wolff-olins-amv-bbdo/>, March 12th 2024

³⁰ “France's Decathlon springs into rebrand ahead of Paris Olympics”, <https://www.euronews.com/business/2024/03/14/frances-decathlon-springs-into-rebrand-ahead-of-paris-olympics>, March 14th 2024

By early 2024, Decathlon had its presence across 72 countries, where it opened more than 1,700 stores, selling equipment for 85 different sports.³¹ But to grow its business further and to take up a bigger role, the business needed to embrace a bigger brand identity which would break free from its immutable image, which the brand had carefully harnessed for the last 48 years of its business journey. To initiate this process, Decathlon redesigned its logo and introduced a symbol, 'The Orbit'. Explaining the rationale behind the overall overhaul of its brand identity and the message it wanted to convey, Céline Del Genes (Genes), the Chief Customer officer of Decathlon, said, "This new brand identity is a symbol of a new era for Decathlon and reflects our ambition to get people moving through the magic of sport. In addition, it reflects Decathlon's openness to the world. This ambition is served by an ambitious strategy that will allow us to have more impact and reach more people around the world, to help them be healthier and happier, whether they are beginners or high-level athletes."³²

Will Decathlon's New Logo Herald a New Dawn for its Business?

As a part of its business transition plan, Decathlon did extensive research and collected data to understand the general perception of the public about its business. Based on the inputs of the research team, the company realised that the audiences' perception about its business was rather narrow. They saw it as a mere distributor of sports goods.³³ Decathlon wanted to change that image. It wanted its audience to relate to its business through its contribution not only as a mere seller of sports equipment, but as a designer and manufacturer of authentic products. The company claimed that it had 'deeply passionate sports teammates' who were directly involved in its product development. The company wanted to highlight this side of its business. Gariépy stressed, "Our goal is to have a meaningful connection with our customers that extends beyond the act of transaction. This is the reason behind our brand's current evolution, an evolution that will be translated across all our touchpoints."³⁴ The aim was to surpass the traditional and rational appeal that the brand had on its audience because of its high quality and competitive price.

While looking for establishing this connection, the brand also wanted to be perceived more than what it had historically stood for: "Sports for all. All for sports". This time, it decided to nudge its audience with the tag line "Ready to Play?" The tone of this tagline conveyed an emotionally positive vibes and had a universal appeal. Decathlon invited and included those who regularly took part in sports, still not perceived themselves as sportsperson.³⁵ **(Watch YouTube video: CHAPTER 2: VIS ID: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PxOG1jJrnck&t=10s>)** Decathlon wanted to reach out to wider audience, and invited them to take part in sports, because it would boost their 'physical and mental health'.³⁶

To consolidate its playful and inviting image, the brand wanted a revamped visual identity. Decathlon launched a new logo, 'The Orbit'. This visual image had vibrant colour. It aspired to

³¹ "One of the world's biggest sports brands didn't have a logo . . . until now", op.cit.

³² Noland Thomas, "Decathlon: Behind the scenes of an iconic logo change", <https://jai-un-pote-dans-la.com/decathlon-les-coulisses-dun-changement-de-logo-iconique/>, April 26th 2024

³³ "Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play", op.cit.

³⁴ "French Sports Retailer Decathlon Repositioning with Renovated Stores and Brand Signage, Including Canadian Locations", op.cit.

³⁵ "Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play", op.cit.

³⁶ "Decathlon presents new brand identity as it revises global ambitions", op.cit.

capture the dynamism of the brand which stood for 'movement, circularity, and proximity to nature'. The image of mountain in logo, combined the essence of 'sports, the outdoors and sustainability', that the brand stood for.³⁷ Explaining it further Genes said, Decathlon's new logo reminded the audience about the brand's legacy and its dedication for sport worldwide. The icon of the logo featured an 'arc-shaped path of an object'. It resembled 'a planet around a star', which was 'Decathlon's own world'. She also illustrated that the curve, which looked like letter C, stood on behalf of brand's commitment to circularity. The peak in the logo which looked like a mountain reminded brand's connection with nature. It also bespoke its ambition to reach new heights.³⁸ (Exhibit III).

Exhibit III
Decathlon's New Logo



Source: "France's Decathlon springs into rebrand ahead of Paris Olympics",
<https://www.euronews.com/business/2024/03/14/frances-decathlon-springs-into-rebrand-ahead-of-paris-olympics>, March 14th 2024

Wolff Olins, a well-known global brand consultancy agency, had designed Decathlon's new logo, as a part of its effort to revitalise the brand's existing brand identity. The visual image was expected to carry forward the brand's global campaign promoting sports, reflecting its organisation's internal culture and promise for an exclusive brand experience. In that effort, while designing the new logo the designers shunned its age-old simple sans-serif wordmark look and replaced it by a bold and vibrant iconic blue graphic. Nonetheless this image and design would remind brand's iconic Avant Garde wordmark, and infusing sense of motion and artistry which would work seamlessly across all channels. It was fit for the inclusive narratives that the brand stood for to invite people across all 'ages, abilities, and sports'.^{39,40}

Historically Decathlon had a muted visual representation by 'simple sans-serif wordmark'.⁴¹ (Exhibit IV). While launching the new logo it made a sharp deviation from that standpoint. The new logo boldly spoke about brand's vision. This logo communicated that message across various brand touchpoints, and physical products that were sold by the brand.^{42,43} This way, the brand aspired to be at par with other iconic sport brands like, Adidas or Nike; and hog the limelight for its own contribution as a global sports brand. Emma Barratt (Barratt), Global Executive Creative Director at Wolff Olins, elaborated, "At a practical level, Decathlon needed

³⁷ "Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play", op.cit.

³⁸ "Decathlon's transition to a 'multi-specialist company': From logo to store concept", op.cit.

³⁹ "One of the world's biggest sports brands didn't have a logo . . . until now", op.cit.

⁴⁰ May Tom, "Decathlon relaunches as a global sports brand with focus on 'Wonder'",
<https://www.creativeboom.com/news/decathlon-relaunches-as-a-global-sports-brand-with-focus-on-wonder/>,
March 12th 2024

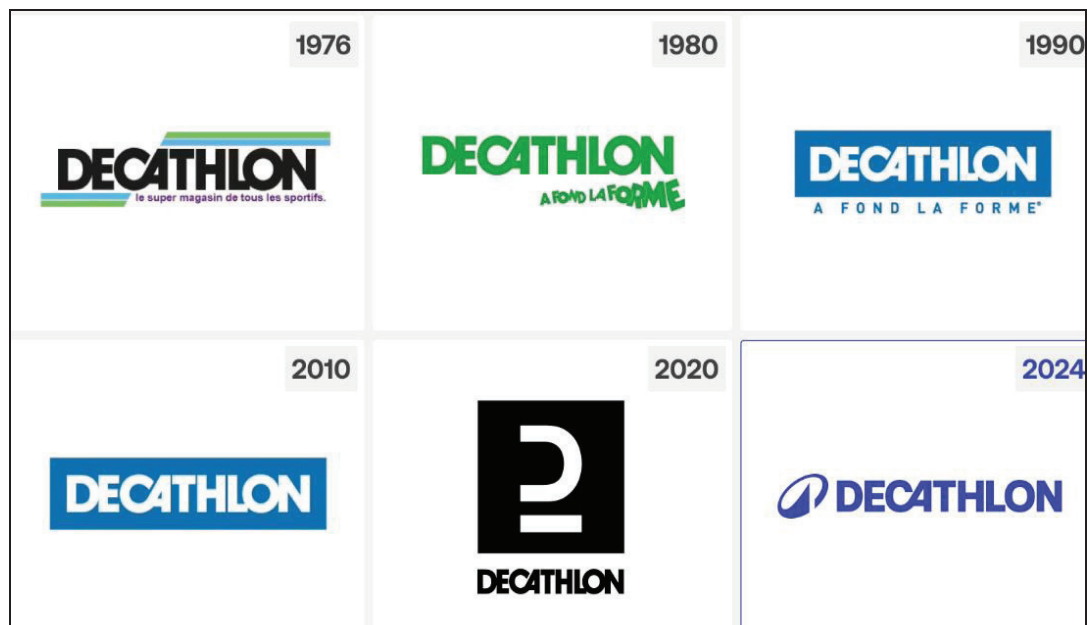
⁴¹ "One of the world's biggest sports brands didn't have a logo . . . until now", op.cit.

⁴² "Decathlon marks a fresh chapter with new branding and campaign", op.cit.

⁴³ "France's Decathlon springs into rebrand ahead of Paris Olympics", op.cit.

a logo that would fit across all its products, big and small... But more importantly, one that marked its position as a global sports brand and also allowed its employees to feel proud.”^{44,45}

Exhibit IV
Evolution of Decathlon's Brand Icon



Source: “A new Decathlon logo: the tip of the iceberg?”, <https://www.digidop.fr/en/blog/nouveau-logo-pour-decathlon-partie-emergee-de-liceberg>, March 15th 2024

While designing Decathlon's logo, the designers wanted to reemphasise the brand's ethos and made it part of its brand's visual identity. Barratt insisted, “Decathlon has always been for everybody... A sportsmaker, misunderstood as a retailer. A democratising influence in sport, fast becoming a leader in circularity. But above all, its aim to simply bring fun, joy and wonder to people of all levels and abilities. We have honoured this with the new brand and identity, which is an open invitation for all to move in their own way.” So, the logo design conveyed brand's strategic approach towards sports. The brand had always promoted sports for everybody, not only for the winners. It invited people to take part in sports because it led to enjoyment and fun. The brand's mission had been: ‘to move people through the wonders of sport’. The iconography of Decathlon's new logo incorporated all the positive elements of sports. It represented enjoyment, connection, adventure, and at the same time it celebrated movement, encouraged participation and pushed for progress.⁴⁶

Many branding experts believed that Decathlon's new logo perfectly embodied the brand's new positioning, ‘Make sport yours’. It immaculately carried the message of brand transformation and signified the brand's journey away from ‘perfectionism and elitism, towards participation and pleasure’. They believed that the new logo of Decathlon highlighted “democratic and people-centred approach to sport.” It had indeed facilitated brand

⁴⁴ “One of the world's biggest sports brands didn't have a logo . . . until now”, op.cit.

⁴⁵ “Decathlon marks a fresh chapter with new branding and campaign”, op.cit.

⁴⁶ “Decathlon relaunches as a global sports brand with focus on 'Wonder'”, op.cit.

communication by integrating most of the product and service features that Decathlon had been offering through its business.^{47,48}

In addition to that, while expanding its business across many geographic locations, like other brands, Decathlon had to take into considerations unique characteristics of each place where it was opening its stores. It needed to acknowledge local 'cultural and linguistic diversity'. The brand believed that its new visual identity would help in overcoming many such barriers and help its business to make its mark in the existing brand ecosystem in diverse locations. It also believed to reach out to the new generation customers, this kind of visual icon was essential to bridge the gap between the people's perception and the brand's ambition. Gariépy said, "Since our customers are changing, we need to evolve with them and we also need to reflect our new ambition of becoming seen as more of a sports brand."⁴⁹

To execute that plan, in March 2024, the brand declared that it was going to refurbish its nearly 1,700 global stores. In all its touchpoints the company was going to feature its logo. With that, Decathlon claimed that its stores would be revamped with "a whole new setup that will offer customers intuitive navigation, increased product visibility and engaging physical and digital displays, and an aesthetically pleasing atmosphere."⁵⁰ Decathlon was the official sponsor of Paris 2024 Olympics. That explained the timing of the logo launch just before the Olympics. The event was the right platform to maximise the visibility.⁵¹

To create the buzz about its revised brand positioning, Decathlon was gradually stepping up its investment on marketing, but still marketers felt that Decathlon's visibility compared to other sports brands, like Nike, Adidas, and Under Armour was relatively low. Understanding the local audience many such brands were spending large amount to rope in famous celebrities who had mass appeal. But so far Decathlon chose not to follow that herd. Even while opening stores, Decathlon defied the trend, rather chose to be the trend setter with big stores.⁵² These stores were used to establish its community connect.⁵³

Decathlon earned its reputation by offering quality product at an affordable price, for its innovative products and services and for its dedication to pursue the sustainability goal.⁵⁴ It did not spend huge money on marketing or sponsoring or endorsing events. The company's official website proudly declared: "Our strategy is simple - we believe every money we save on marketing, advertising or sponsorship helps us reduce the price of our products - which in turn helps us make sport accessible to the many."⁵⁵ Nonetheless to connect with the sports enthusiasts, the company had programmes to promote them through its official page or social networking sites, where they were featured as 'fun-fluencer' or 'influencer'. The

⁴⁷ "Decathlon marks a fresh chapter with new branding and campaign", op.cit.

⁴⁸ "One of the world's biggest sports brands didn't have a logo . . . until now", op.cit.

⁴⁹ "Decathlon is ready to rebrand, and play", op.cit.

⁵⁰ "Decathlon unveils global rebrand as it overhauls logo, stores, and business model", op.cit.

⁵¹ "France's Decathlon springs into rebrand ahead of Paris Olympics", op.cit.

⁵² Sood K Anil and Majumdar Debleena, "The Decathlon effect: How a French retailer is moving India beyond cricket", <https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/prime/consumer/the-decathlon-effect-how-a-french-retailer-is-moving-india-beyond-cricket-/immersivestories/101670887.cms>, July 14th 2023

⁵³ "Decathlon's transition to a 'multi-specialist company': From logo to store concept", op.cit.

⁵⁴ "Decathlon Results Back New Strategy To Take On Sports Super Brands", op.cit.

⁵⁵ "Decathlon: Do you sponsor events/activities?", <https://www.decathlon.in/support/249/do-you-sponsor-events-activities>

company supported them with free gear or offering them paid opportunities. For the same purpose it even looked for involving influential content creators.⁵⁶

However, with the launch of new logo at Paris Olympics 2024, the brand had decided to make a bold statement.⁵⁷ This change stood as an attempt to encapsulate the brand's ambition. As Coppola said: "The (sports) world is not standing still and changes (far too) quickly. Change is also the story of Decathlon... It's time to make more impact because we have a goal to achieve: making sport accessible to everyone, as sport is for everyone."⁵⁸ Adding to that, Amna B., Marketing Lead at HulkApps opined, "Decathlon's journey through its rebranding phase and beyond illuminates the roadmap for sustainable growth and innovation within the retail sector. Its strategic pivot towards digital enhancement, coupled with an unwavering commitment to sustainability and recommerce, serves as a beacon for other enterprises aiming to stay relevant in a rapidly evolving marketplace. As we look towards the future, it's clear that Decathlon's endeavors in rebranding and beyond are not just reshaping its business landscape but are also contributing significantly to the broader narrative of sustainable and responsible retailing."⁵⁹

⁵⁶ "Decathlon: Ambassadors", <https://www.decathlon.com/pages/become-a-decathlon-ambassador>

⁵⁷ "France's Decathlon springs into rebrand ahead of Paris Olympics", op.cit.

⁵⁸ "Decathlon's transition to a 'multi-specialist company': From logo to store concept", op.cit.

⁵⁹ B. Amna, "How Decathlon's Bold Rebranding is Shaping the Future of Sports Retail", <https://www.hulkapps.com/blogs/ecommerce-hub/how-decathlons-bold-rebranding-is-shaping-the-future-of-sports-retail>